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Ray Conniff

The fall of 1997 was an eventful time for Ray Conniff as he celebrated his 81st birthday and the release of his 100th album, "I Love Movies." Ray has become a legend in the music world as an arranger, producer and creator of "a sound." His distinctive blend of big band, orchestral and vocal scoring captured the ears of American listeners in the late 1950s and became a familiar sound on radio and home stereos. He started as a trombonist and arranger in the active years of swing, writing for Bunny Berigan, Artie Shaw, Benny Goodman and other big band leaders. His association with Mitch Miller at Columbia Records led to his first records under his own name, and he now places on the top ten all-time album sellers. His six decade career in music is testament to an acute business sense and the ability to create scores which satisfy his love of arranging while honoring the melody of the song.

Ray currently lives in Los Angeles, and was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 14, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming in San Diego for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I am honored to have Mr. Ray Conniff with me — trombonist and arranger and composer. And I want to tell you that when I grew up, in the 50s, I lived outside Rochester, New York, and it was kind of a typical suburban home, and in my house, my parents played Glenn Miller and a little Basie, and a lot of Ray Conniff. So it's a real pleasure for me to be talking with you today, because your sound is something that was present a lot as I grew up. I think probably it's a pretty huge compliment to have people refer to "a sound," you know, like "well what we need is that Ray Conniff sound." And it's been a long road, but would you do it all again?

RC: Would I what?

MR: Would you do it all again?

RC: [coughs] pardon me. I hope there won't be too much of that going on. I've got one of these California flu bugs or something. Oh, sure, you know, as we live life at the time, when we're doing, like now what we're doing, we think we're doing the right thing for now. And I guess if you went back and looked at every now, you thought you were doing — I can see times when I probably could have done something a little differently, but I think on the whole, yeah, I've been very fortunate. Well the main thing I guess I've been fortunate about is that there aren't a lot of men probably that go through a lifetime and do what they really love to do. You know and I have had that happen to me in this life, and I'm very grateful for that, yeah. You mentioned the 50s, and your family, and playing

exposed to music, you know, from my mom and dad as a child. And see I have recollections of five and six you know, musical recollections. And so what are we talking about? Well '56 I did my first album, for Columbia Records. So we're talking about 40 years, right in the middle of the whole thing, when you started hearing it. People thought in 1956, when my first album came out, like they think about everybody that becomes popular. "Wow, overnight guy here, where's he been?" But as you think about it there have been 40 years of exposure to music, and my dad played piano, a little piano — he used to play mostly ump-chink chords and sing me little humorous songs you know, and that tickled the heck out of me. But, those little ump-chink chords instilled a rhythm into me, and made me very conscious of rhythm. And then he also played trombone. When I got a little older he taught me to play the trombone when I was about nine. And my mom played piano and used to sing songs to me. So I was exposed to music. I'm 81 now, so I was exposed to music about 40 years when you first heard about me.

MR: The songs that they were playing for you, they were probably considered popular music of that day, were they mostly vocal songs that they had, that you would sing along to?

RC: You know that's a very interesting question because as I think about it, the music that I used to hear them play and sing, I can remember one, there was one thing that my mother would play, and she would sing like a little soprano lead and my dad would sing like a little obbligato tenor part. And I can't remember what the piece was, but it was some semi-classical piece, and they used to do that sort of thing. But then you know sometimes people will come up to me like now, in this period of time that we're doing this interview, I'll do an interview and someone will say like, "don't you think some of the music today is really dumb?" You know, and I remember one night they came home and they used to have minstrel shows in those days. And one night they came home from a minstrel show, and my dad was singing, "yes we have no bananas — we have no bananas today." You know and I mean how dumb can a song be? And so it's always been that way. There's been great music and then there's been very, like frivolous music you know, and then there's been junk, like that isn't even music, like rap is that music you know?

MR: No.

RC: It's rhythm with some story and rhymes and stuff. And music hasn't changed a lot from what I used to be exposed to.

MR: I think you said a very important thing when you talked about how the ump-chick of your father playing instilled that rhythm in you. Because you can hear that in your arrangements. Do you think that's one of the keys to what's made your arranging so successful?

RC: Well you know, you ask very good questions by the way. Up to that point that you're talking about, when you started hearing my music, I wasn't before that, prior to that, like when I went through the quote big band era, where I played with the bands like the first big band I played with was Bunny Berigan in 1938. I played trombone and arranged music as well for the band. Then I did the same thing with the Bob Crosby band in 1939, and then I went with the Artie Shaw band in 1940. And now from '40 through '45 I think I played with three different Artie Shaw bands, and wrote arrangements and played trombone, beside such greats as Jack Jenney and Vernon Brown were in the band. But anyway, during that era — and then I wrote for the Harry James band in 1946. That whole period, and up to where you pointed out when the first album of my own came out, I wrote with a different objective in mind. To me, it was fun and it was a big kick if I wrote a chart as we call them, and I brought it in to the band and they rehearsed it — Jack Jenney or Georgie Auld or Bunny Berigan band or Joe Bushkin in the Bunny Berigan band, or Buddy Rich was in the Bunny Berigan first band I was in. They said, "hey that was a great arrangement, Ray, I like that thing you did on 'Little Gate.'" I said, "Oh, thanks." "Little Gate" was the band boy's name. You know, we never thought, who's going to know who "Little Gate" is you know? We didn't think commercially. We just thought, I just thought I wonder how the guys are going to like it. I wrote for the guys. I wrote for Bunny, I wrote for the guys. I wrote for Bob Crosby and the guys in the band. I wrote for Artie Shaw and the guys in the band. I never thought about the people out there that were paying our bills, you know that were paying our salaries, that went to the dances, that listened to us on the air, that bought our records. You know, I didn't care, I never gave them a second thought. I went through a period I call the lean years, and that was gee, I can't pin it down, I know I'd been writing for the Harry James Band, '46 — I remember the first thing I did for Harry I still had my soldier suit on, I wrote a thing called "Easy," an original. And Harry and I had a parting of the ways because a few years down the road, I was doing an awful lot of writing for Harry, I wrote a lot of originals for him. And I remember I went into, he had a song for me to do and the name of the song was "Ruby." And he said, "By the way, why don't you write a little bit, kind of a bop treatment on this?" Bop was kind of a new school of music that was coming along, and I never did dig bop. I liked to listen to it and I think we had some great players like Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker. But it was not my bag you know? I like to hear the rhythm, the driving four-four, as Zeke Zarchy always called it, "the driving four-four of the northern American Negro." And I always liked to hear that, like Buddy Rich played that kind of drums you know. And oh let's see if I can think of anyone else, I can't think of any drummers, oh who was the great drummer that was the Shaw bands, one of the first

And bop was kind of supposed to be a floating type of rhythm on top cymbals and stuff. You weren't supposed to hear it, you were supposed to feel it here. You were supposed to feel what he was trying — and I don't know, I never felt that, so I said, "Hey you know, Harry, I just don't feel that kind of music," and you know, "maybe it's time you got another boy." And his jaw dropped. He looked at me and he couldn't believe what I was saying. And he said, "well, okay." So I left the band. For two years I thought all I had to do was pick up the phone and call my old pals, you know, like Sonny Burke at Decca and Paul Weston was at Columbia Records. And I called all of them and told them, "hey I'm free now, I'm not writing steady all the time for Harry, I'm available." And boy, for two years the phone hardly rang. And finally after sitting waiting for the phone to ring for two years I got so discouraged I thought — I had a wife and a mother I was supporting, and three children, and we were living out in Reseda, and I thought, I've got to go get a job. I can't go on like this. I took a job — they were converting a ten acre, it was a melon field, into a subdivision out in Reseda. And I went out and took a job as a laborer, cleaning up the ditches behind the ditch digger. Where he'd make mistakes on the corner, I'd clean the ditches. And I got to thinking, wow, what happened? Which way did they go, you know. I was making, in 1940, Artie was paying me $300 a week, you know, which in those days was a lot of money. And here I am out digging ditches, you know, for $60 a week. But it gave me a lot of time to think. But anyway I took an awful long — I've got to start pinning my answers down, it took a long time to answer your question — but I started thinking completely different about writing arrangements. I thought, what if I started writing for the people that paid the bills, the people that listened, the people that bought the records you know. And I started thinking more along the lines of commercially, and I thought about, you know everything in life is rhythm. Our heartbeat is a rhythm, each day is a rhythm, the sun rises and sets to a rhythm, and the ocean tides go in and out to a rhythm, the cycles of the seasons are a rhythm. And I thought rhythm is very important in our life, and I made the rhythm very predominant. And then I remembered when I first started thinking about the opposite sex. There was a little girl down the street that I had a terrible crush on. I must have been I don't know, ten, eleven, twelve, something like that. And she was always singing a song, it was [sings], "ooooh, would you like to take a walk — ooooh, do you think it's going to rain — and something's gonna come from that" is the name of the song. And to this day, I've heard that song once in a while, people will play an old record or a disc jockey. It still moves something. I thought, if I can catch the songs that people fell in love to the first few times, I've got a wonderful idea. And that's what I did. I went back and I thought, when I got my first chance to do an album in 1956, a "wonderful" album, which you heard, or

them — I picked songs, and by arithmetic I went back the number of years, the age group I was trying to hit was 18-35 in the market. So I went back, when were those 18 to 35 year olds hearing, "ooooh would you like to take a walk" with the little girl down the street, or the boy you know, and so by arithmetic I picked songs from the top ten of those years. And that's what "S' Wonderful," "S' Marvelous," "S' Awful Nice." So in other words I didn't change my style of writing that much. I still wrote for brass and saxes, big band style, with a predominant rhythm sound, and I added the voices quite accidentally. It was just an experiment on a single I originally was backing for Columbia Records. And Mitch Miller was head of all the artists at Columbia. He came running out and he says, "this is a great sound. We've got to get you back in the studio, have you do a couple of sides, Ray Conniff, orchestra and chorus, and use that orchestra and chorus sound." And so the first thing we did was a single. It was called on one side was "Begin the Beguine," and I did some more research and found out that the two songs that had sold the most records, had the most sheet music, and playing, the most airplay and it was "Begin the Beguine" and "Stardust." That was in 1956. And we put the single out. And it became like a turntable hit. It was played day and night by disc jockeys all over the United States. And as a matter of fact, well no it wasn't until the album — the single, oddly enough, wasn't selling very much, with saturation airplay. And Columbia Records would have meetings in the marketing. "What is it with this Conniff? We're not selling his single and that's all you hear on the air." And a fellow by the name of Hal Cook in marketing come up with the answer. He says "you know, I think we're on the wrong track with Ray Conniff. He's not a single artist. He's an album artist. Get him back in the studio with ten more songs and put out an album, and I think we'll have something." And so that's what we did. And one of the other ten songs was "S' Wonderful," which we decided to use for the title song, and I used that instruments and — voices and instrument sound and the predominant rhythm sound, and the idea about people falling in love to the songs, and then that album, and the title song of that, "S' Wonderful," that became a turntable hit. It was on a chart that *Billboard* magazine had for about, I don't know, it's not on any longer, but it was only ten albums would appear on that chart, and the chart said, "albums most played by disc jockeys" and it was on that list of ten for about nine or ten months. It would be on at five and it would go to seven or eight, it would go back, it would go to two or three, it would go back to nine, and I'd think well that's it, then it would go back to four, and back to six. It stayed on there for nine or ten months with airplay. But it really didn't sell quite a bit until about six months. I mean it was negligible — fairly good sales, but after six months it was like your mom and dad or whoever were buying the records in those days, thought okay, somebody says, you can go buy it now if you want.

They'd heard it so much, the airplay was wonderful. Finally they started going in and it became a gold record. And then we started following it up with a lot of others like it.

MR: That's so interesting, that I mean it was very astute of you to really have that time off and spend that time digging ditches and really thinking about, now what am I going to do now, and really think about what people wanted to hear and songs they fell in love with, so that you were bringing the business and the music together. Where too often sometimes the businessmen don't really know music at all. And you pulled them right together.

RC: Yeah, they knew what I was doing too, and they liked the idea too of what I was doing. As a matter of fact I went to a place, a company called Institute of Motivational Research. They got very much interested in the project, and without charging me, they did some research on my product, and then Columbia Records got them into it and we did it further. But you know what was fun about it though, was I didn't go all the way down the line and do like, you know Guy Lombardo commercial style, or — I can't think of any other real commercial bands of that time. But I was doing like a big band sound with voices, and I was using the guys that were playing all those things out on the road in the days I was on the road. Like Billy Butterfield was playing lead trumpet, Lou McGarity was playing lead trombone, Panama Francis was in the rhythm section, Dick Hyman was playing piano, and if I couldn't get Dick I'd get Johnny Guarnieri. And the guys that played with Benny's band, Hymie Schertzer and Toots Mondello were playing the alto saxophone, Georgie Auld was playing tenor, Jerry Jerome was playing tenor you know. It was an all-star band playing written arrangements by a guy that used to write for the big bands, but was now writing big band style for the people. And the people dug it. They could understand it, you know, because they could hear the melody, even when the guys would play solos, they'd kind of hang around the melody because they knew what I was trying to do you know. I used to write the solos out, and they stayed pretty close to them. And so it was fun to have hit records and be doing something we all enjoyed doing as well.

MR: Let me play something for you here.

RC: Okay.

MR: And talking about your arranging.

RC: Would it be all right if I used one of these?

MR: Sure.

[audio interlude]

MR: Does that ring a bell with you?

RC: Yeah, that's originally Artie Shaw, isn't it?

RC: Yeah. In 1940 we recorded that, yeah.

MR: So at this point, you were still writing for the guys in the band, but it still had that very predominant rhythm thing happening, right up front.

RC: Well it's strange that you picked that particular recording out, because on that particular recording, you know, all through the years working with the bands, and I really started playing I guess, you play professionally when you get paid for a gig. And the first time I got paid for a gig it was in 1933 when I was in high school. And so all through the years, and I was writing at the same time. I must tell you sometime during the interview how I started writing. I got a little device called a "lightning arranger." I paid a dollar for a mail order device and I wrote my first arrangement with a dollar mail order device. But anyway, you write yourself, don't you? Yeah. Well you probably, I don't know if you're anything like me, I think out of every hundred arrangements I probably write, there's one that I think really came off either recording or the way I wrote or everything. And this was one when I brought this in and heard this, and heard it performed, I thought, this is one of the best things I've ever done for coming together you know, for the whole, the routine, the whole thing. And I thought if I ever get my own group, I'm going to re-record that again. And I would say there were two that I did like that during my whole career with the big bands. The other one was Harry James' "September Song." That turned out great too. And both of those arrangements, you know I was trying to give it, as you probably do, all my best effort, you know, my best shot, and work a long time before I put any notes down. But those two really turned out. So I did re-record both of those. So you picked one that even though it was written with the older era of the guys in the band and Artie Shaw, the thought that went into it turned out, although it didn't use the hit formula idea, the way all the elements came together was, I would say, even though it's with a great jazz band, it's commercial you know. People can understand it. They can hear the melody, they can feel the rhythm.

MR: And they were still dancing to the music at that time.

RC: Yeah.

MR: And so it had that kind of — it was a touch of Latin beat in there too.

RC: Yeah I think I always had that. I remember one of the early people that do interviews asked me, "what are the highlights that you think about," you know in your whole life of music. And one of them, I mentioned that I was born in Attleboro, Massachusetts. And in our house, there was a basement. My dad practically built the house with his own hands. There was a basement, a first floor which had a kitchen, a front hall, living room and dining room, and then the second floor had the bedrooms and a bathroom, and then above, what we used to call the attic. And that was where you kept all the junk you know,

was an old Edison cylinder type Victrola. And there were some of the old records there. And I discovered first, my first initiation into music really, except for what I told you about my mom and dad playing, was to hear the Borodin "Peasant Overture." And that was a real charge to me. I couldn't believe things could be like that musically. And I sat and must have listened to that thing for two hours. And then I started looking at some of the other things and there was a lot of Latin stuff there. And I listened to a lot of Latin stuff, and I think I got a feel for Latin very early on from that. And that stuck with me.

MR: And plus your records now, over the years, have been very popular in those countries, in addition to here.

RC: Yeah. One period of time, after quite a few years with the label that I originally went with, I got a call from the Latin division and they said they were getting a lot of calls from South American countries who wanted Ray Conniff to do an album of just Latin music. And so I did my first Latin album, it was called something Latino — Simply Latino ["Latinisimo"], was that it? I can't remember. But anyway after that it became very successful in South America, and I did quite a few after that, beamed right out to Latin countries only.

MR: Do you think it helped also that your vocals were using — they weren't singing the lyrics so that there was no language thing there?

RC: Oh yeah. You hit on something that I usually bring out in an interview when I talk about that first album, and they usually say, "what do you think made your albums successful?" And I think that was one of the things. I didn't have any language barrier. And when Columbia Records sent samples out all over the world, that original "S' Wonderful" album was picked up all over the world and became quite popular all over the world, as did a lot of the follow up albums. And that was one of the things. Doing the great songs of like Cole Porter, George Gershwin and Jerome Kern, and I had a vocal sound in there with the chorus, but usually when record companies of the U.S.A., which were very big you know, would send samples out to other countries of singers singing these songs of Cole Porter and Gershwin and so forth, they would be in English and there would be a language barrier. And here Ray Conniff comes out with these great songs, with no language barrier, but they still had the voice in there, and they liked that. And so those records became popular all over the world. And you know that I think together with the choice of the material, and the rhythm sound, the voices with instruments and no language barrier, and the idea of picking the hits that people would connect with when they first fell in love, I think that was kind of a three point formula that made it successful all over the world and kept it successful.

MR: Did you start to hear some imitators?

RC: Oh yeah, there were a lot of them. As a matter of fact I wasted about two years of my life trying to find a way to stop them from doing it. And I had attorneys and copyright attorneys and regular attorneys, and we did a lot of research. We found out, they found out that I couldn't — it's different now, you can copyright arrangements now — well you could in those days but it was a very complicated thing I ran into. I finally found that the best thing for me to do was to forget about all the imitators, and just keep going on ahead and move ahead, and what came to me, and not worry about if someone else is imitating me. And I found out that they all fell by the wayside, it wasn't really a — there was only one that really survived and he didn't survive by copying. There was a fellow in Europe that became quite popular and he originally copied me when he started, but eventually he developed his own style and became — James Last — he became quite well known in Europe.

MR: It seems that the instrumental sound at that time — let me rephrase that — we don't hear as many instrumental hits anymore you know. You had your music and every once in a while something would come up like "A Walk in the Black Forest," by Horst Jankowski I think his name was, and then of course the Tijuana Brass. And that it was still possible to have instrumental music be big sellers. I don't know where that fell by the wayside. I don't think we hear that that much anymore, just purely instrumental music, unless it's Kenny G I guess he's a name we know.

RC: Yeah. The last one I can really thing of [scats].

MR: "The Hustle," yeah.

RC: That was a big hit. What was his name? I can't think of his name.

MR: Do the hustle.

RC: Yeah you're right. Like in the old days, the big bands had a lot of instrumental hits, "In the Mood," and "String of Pearls" and those kind of things. But you know I think probably even in the old days, for every instrumental hit, weren't there three or four vocal hits? With lyrics? I think instrumental hits have never been the big thing, but I don't think it's changed a lot but it is true. I think in my own case, in Latin countries I've had a lot of instrumental hits, like "Besame Mucho" was a tremendous hit, my arrangement of that was a big hit in Latin America. When we do tours down there, we include several songs, there's "Besame Mucho" — when I play that they'll all start singing the arrangement. And "Green Eyes" was another one down there. "Beyond the Sea" was a big hit down there, "Brazil" was a big hit. "Night and Day." There was an album I did down there it was called "A Touch of Latin" and it had all of those songs in it. And we almost have to include those when we do tours or they'll ask for them from the audience. And so that would be the exception with me. I've had a lot of instrumental hits down there.

RC: Oh it was called a "lightning arranger." Yeah. That was about 1934, I was a junior in high school, or no, I was a senior by then. And I was playing with this little band. We were playing stocks you know. And we had trumpet, trombone — well we never could get a good second trumpet. We usually had trumpet and trombone and sometimes if we had a bigger gig we'd have three brass. And three saxes and drums and piano. And we could never get a good bass player. And we'd play stocks. But anyway we played for the school dances you know. And one day I was looking for something in my dad's room. And he was secretary of the musicians' union in Attleboro, Massachusetts, played trombone in the marching band you know, and took care of their business for them. And I was looking for something in the desk and he subscribed to *Billboard* magazine. And I started thumbing through it. And down in the lower right corner, I remember it was the right hand page, was a little box about, I don't know, a couple inches, less than a couple of inches high, it said "Lightning Arranger." I can't remember the wording, but learn to arrange overnight, you know, instantaneous arranging. What it was, it was a transposing device. And in this way — is it okay if I write, oh I don't have a pencil, yeah I think I have something. It was — we used to call it celluloid. Is it okay if I write on here? Now we call it plastic. But it was about, let me see I'll get this up to the camera after, okay, and I'll give you an idea. Because it's easy to understand if you see this. There was, okay, I won't go this whole, but I'll show you how one of the wheels would look. Okay. Now there were two plastic pieces, and you know picture one of these and then another one. And in between there was a wheel in here, see? And you could turn the wheels here. Then there were slots. I didn't put all the slots in. And you could turn it over and there were more slots see, on the back. So here would say like it would say concert instruments, like piano. It would give a C chord. You'd have a C, a G, E and a C. The C chord. Then here it would say B flat trumpets. And it would say D, A, F sharp, D. Then here would say E flat saxophones, which would be what A, E, C sharp A you know. And so you had the C chord here, and if you wanted to write for with what I play trumpet, we had a trumpet, E flats, and we had tenor saxophone, which also comes under the heading of the trumpets, you know, the B flat trumpet. So I could write a C chord for those four instruments, and know what notes to write for them. And then over on this side here, on these slots over here, this would say C7.

MR: Okay, we've got the dominant chords coming.

RC: And this would be for C7, and then there would be slots that say ninths. Here would say diminished, augmented, and you'd turn over and you'd have the whole ball of wax. So I thought this was great. So I took the ninth thing and I put it down and I just happened to have it on F7 see? So I played the F7, no I had it on F9, no I had an F7. So I played the

the fifths. And the next slot was B flat 7. So I struck the B flat 7 and held the thing down. I turned it another notch and hit the E flat 7. Wow. That's "Sweet Georgia Brown," you know? And so I wrote my first arrangement, and I turned it over and I did, instead of F7 I did the ninth chords. And I did "Sweet Georgia Brown," for trumpet, trombone and three saxes. And I used the five way, no double lead you know. And it was like Duke was writing in those days. And I brought that into the guys and they fell on the floor [scats]. And you know with just five ways — imagine what that sound — nobody had ever heard anything like that. You know they weren't writing like that then.

MR: That's a great story.

RC: So for one dollar —

MR: How long did you hold on to that thing?

RC: Oh boy do I wish I had that today, yeah. For one dollar, what an investment. And of course I used it for a while as a transposing device, but that led me into writing, because later on I studied and I would, I started with Hugo Friedhofer, by the way, boy he was great. Do you remember him? He wrote for the motion pictures out here on the west coast. And then I ran into, who was it, somebody tipped me off to start looking into the classics, and I started taking Tchaikovsky's scores — did you ever do that? You take like "Romeo and Juliet" and you put it down, everything down into concert so you can look at it quicker. I re-scored it down into concert, and the simplicity of Tchaikovsky's writing was amazing when you saw it that way. And also that's where I started learning the beauty of — I think that's one thing that's a little missing today. Did you by the way see — who's the great fellow, the interviewer, the top interviewer on CNN, what's his name?

MR: Not Ted Koppel.

RC: No, no, no, no. Larry King. He had Eric Clapton on. And he was playing guitar, and I think except the way I heard him and his writings with the guitar, mainly today, well a point I want to make is a lot of today's music is being written by guitar players. You can't — with the guitar you miss the beauty of a Tchaikovsky, like [scats], you know the third in the bass. The seventh and the bass. With a guitar you always have the tonic in the bass. And I think that's missing a little bit in the younger writers today. They write with the guitar. They need to study those classics and see the beauty, the great sound of a third in the bass and not doubled in the harmony. You know, leave the third out in the harmony. It's only down there. There's something about that, it just moves me, I don't know.

MR: It's interesting you mention that, because if you look at — recently I was looking at some of the music from "West Side Story," and "One Hand One Heart." And that's what Bernstein did. He had very simple chords, but he would put the third in the bass, and it

RC: Well if you took Tchaikovsky and put the melody in the bass line, you've practically got a composition and a score like this you know. But with today's writers, everything's going like this. But there's something about that contrary motion and the movement of the bass, it's great. But I learned that from breaking those scores down, you know, and I thought wow, what a sound, that's great, that's how they do that, huh? And I'd hunt, and wait a minute now, have an F chord and there would be an A in the bass, and I'd be looking, it must be, he's got guys way up in there, he must have an A somewhere there. And I'd look at it — no A. No A. It's only down in the bass.

MR: That's an important lesson too, in that I know that I've thought sometimes when I've been trying to orchestrate something and I don't have enough notes, and gee, this guy's got nothing to play. And you're tempted, instead of giving him a rest, to give that person a note to play. But maybe it's not really necessary.

RC: Oh you know, that's a great lesson. I learned that from Hugo — I learned it, he taught me, but I don't use it all the time, he'd say, "Ray, one of the things that you can learn, the fewer guys you use to get the desired result, and the fewer notes you use to get the desired result that you're after, it's always going to sound better." And that's a hard one. You've got 60 guys there, you want everybody playing all the time, you know, especially the producer, wants everybody playing all the time — "we're paying them aren't we?" And sometimes you have only one-third or one-tenth of them playing, and then bring them in, and then let it come out, and then let it go back down to just a few guys you know. We don't talk like this all the time do we? We have nuances when we talk. We talk like this, we emphasize things, and de-emphasize things. And music has to be the same way.

MR: Let me ask you a kind of a business question. As you became a well known arranger and producer and so forth, were you able to get better business arrangements with your record company? Did you kind of hold more power in the structure of things?

RC: Gee, as I became what?

MR: Well you must have had an arrangement like with Columbia, did you get a percentage of the recording? Were you on contract?

RC: Oh I started out like all the rest of the artists. The first break I got was through Mitch Miller. I met Mitch when I was writing for Harry James' band, and he would come out to the west coast, and sit in the booth and oversee the sessions. And when I first went back to New York, this is let's say five or six years later, after I'd been doing arranging for Harry James, I went back — I'd been on the west coast for a while and I decided gee I used to do, I was doing well, but I thought I could be doing better. It seemed like I'm not quite fulfilling what I could really do. And I came in as a trombonist on a record session

you doing in New York?" And I said, "well I'm in town now," and you know we used to talk about my ideas that I was telling you about, writing commercially for the people about when they fell in love and the time period and the predominance of the rhythm. I said, "you know if you need any arranging done, I'm here, available now," and he says, "fine, I'll keep you in mind" the old line you know — don't call us we'll call you. And I thought oh the same old thing. But sure enough, two weeks later he called me, and he got me in to do backings for a girl called Eileen Rogers. And by the way, while I was out in California, during the lean years, I forgot to tell you about this, you know I told you about the lean years? I went out and at the suggestion of Frank DeVol, I bought a book called *The Grammar of Conducting*. Did you ever see that book? You buy yourself a mirror and you put it up on the wall and you get the music stand, and you picture the full orchestra, all 60 of them, and you conduct "Romeo and Juliet" and you cue everything you know, and you do the whole thing, and you learn you don't conduct like this. And you keep time, this is a one, and most guys that don't do it, they just lead like this all the time. But anyway so I studied *The Grammar of Conducting*, and I started taking piano lessons, which I never did overcome, I never became accomplished on the keyboard. And I would practice the trombone, and I would write. And so anyway, so now it's coming together. So he called me in about an Eileen Rogers, two sides. And he said to me at the close of the interview, she was there, I got her key you know. I can remember the two songs, it was "Now is the Time," and "Just a Little Bit More." That's how vivid this whole thing is in my mind. And he said as I'm going out the door he said, "by the way, why don't you write yourself a couple of trombone parts if you want to make yourself a couple extra bucks." And as I tell you this story, what I'm going to tell you now, took place in about ten seconds. It takes a long time to tell it, but it took place back and forth, a little exchange. The first exchange was, "why don't you write yourself a couple of trombone parts if you want to make yourself a couple of extra bucks." And I says, "well who's conducting?" And this, if you knew me in those days, I'm such an introvert. For me to ask a question like this, God must have been looking over me. I don't know how I ever asked that question. And he said, "well I've got a conductor." It was a split session. You know how they'd put four songs in on a side, and one artist would do two songs, and another would do two songs. Don Cherry was doing two songs, and Eileen Rogers, my artist was doing two songs. So what he's telling me is, "I've got a conductor hired, Norm Layton is going to be conducting" for Don Cherry, you know, it's a split session. And I asked the question. So this is the way it went. So he says, "Write yourself a couple of trombone parts." "Well who's going to conduct?" And he said, "why would you like to conduct?" And I said, "well yeah." He said okay. That's how long it took for me to

got a conductor, I'll bring the arrangements in and give them to him. So this was the first time. Up to now in my career, I'm bringing arrangements, giving them to Harry James, he's setting the tempo. I'm giving them to Artie Shaw, he's setting the tempos. I'm not up there. So this is the first time I come in with two charts, and I set the tempos, I tell them how to play them, I go in the booth and tell them how to balance them. And so Mitch was tickled to death. He thought this is great. This guy is great. So he started giving me all his artists. I did Don Cherry's "Band of Gold," do you remember that a little later? Then I did Johnnie Ray "Just Walking in the Rain." And by the way, Dick Hyman did the whistling on that. That had a little hook in it, the whistle. And I did "Singing the Blues" with the through-the-teeth whistle like Haggart does? I did the whistle on "Singing the Blues." And I did the early Johnny Mathis' "Chances Are" it's not for me to say, with the piano hook. [scats].

MR: Sounds like whoever did "I Left My Heart in San Francisco" must have heard that recording.

RC: Yeah, they copied it from that, yeah. And then yeah, that was used again in that. And anyway, and then I did the Marty Robbins stuff, "White Sport Coat." So Mitch — you asked about the deal. Mitch said, at a meeting, he said, "hey everything this Conniff guy's doing is getting on the charts," you know. And so he was going out to the west coast, and he said, "I won't be using you for a couple of weeks, I'm going out to the west coast, and I'm going to do Doris Day, Rosie Clooney and Jo Stafford." And I said, "Oh, why don't you take me with you?" And he says, "You wanna go with me?" And I says, "Yeah, I'd like to go with you." He said, "I'll tell you what. You pay your own plane fare, I'll give you all three artists, you do four charts for each artist," that would be twelve charts I'd do, and I was getting I think $150 an arrangement. And I said, "Good, you've got a deal." So I went out with him and we got out there and it turned out one of the artists, I forget who it was, was I guess it was Jo Stafford got what I've got today, kind of a laryngitis thing and couldn't sing. I lost her. Doris Day got into a contractual dispute and decided not to record right then. So all I did was the Rosie Clooney, four sides. And she was great to work with, I thought she was terrific. When I walked in the studio she says, "You're Ray Conniff?" I said, "Yeah." "The arranger?" I says, "Yeah." She says, "You've got to help me." And she grabbed ahold of me and hugged me. And her little body, she was very small then, her little body was just shaking she was so nervous. I says, "Rosie, you're Rosie Clooney, aren't you?" And she says, "Yeah." I says, "You are great, what are you worried about? You are such a great success." She is one of the greatest musicians I've ever worked with. And she sang a note, bing, it was right on the button. I mean she didn't scoop up to the note, she really hit them right in tune and stayed

anyway, so we did the Rosie sessions, and you asked — I still didn't answer the question about the deal. So anyway when we got back — oh Mitch says I'm going to make it up to you when we get back, when we get back to New York. So that's what he did. He gave me that single that I told you about, "Begin the Beguine" and "Stardust." And that was the way he would wheel and deal, which developed into the album. So when the album came along, I said, "Well what's the deal, Mitch." And he said, "Oh don't worry about the deal, you'll talk to me all the time." So they sent me contracts and I signed contracts, you know it's the stock contract is what they say. So I signed a contract, it was three percent.

MR: Three percent.

RC: Three percent. Not three percent of an album, it's three percent after you pay the cost of the jacket you know. These things here, these were selling for what, $3.98 or something back in those days. But the thing inside here.

MR: There's no record inside there.

RC: No, but the thing inside was worth like maybe a dollar or so. That's what you got the three percent on. But anyway.

MR: Oh, wait a minute now, I want to make sure I understand this.

RC: Okay.

MR: You didn't get three percent of what they were actually selling it for. You got three percent of just the record.

RC: The record itself — oh there were a lot of other little clauses. Like they used to be made of, what was it, acetate? They used to break. They had a ten percent breakage clause in there. You know the breakage clause is still in all the contracts? There is nothing that can break anymore. Now they say it's because of the stuff that comes back or something. But anyway, yeah, you got three percent. Oh there were a lot of other things that cut it up. By the time I got all through, I think in those days I used to get eighteen cents on an album in those days. Now it's up much more, and I have a better percentage. But anyway, to get back to your question about the deal, so after a while I was doing everything, you know "S' Wonderful" "S' Marvelous" "S' Awful Nice" were out now. It's a little later down the road. And they're doing quite well, I'm getting gold records. And you know Justin Sogg and all them people were around, and one day I ran into Mitch and I said, "hey Mitch?" He says, "yeah?" We used to have a lot of arguments but we got along great. I says, "hey, what's this contract these guys are giving me at Columbia?" He says, "what do you mean, what do you mean?" I said, "well I'm getting a three percent royalty. Doris Day and" — I can't think of any names — give me some names in those days — well Sinatra, all of them, I said, "they're getting five percent." "Well that's our top — you're

would come out. I never worried about what was in the contract. So it finally got up where I got — I was what they called in those days a flat artist. In other words, I used to go in, they'd pay the cost of my musicians and singers, which was a big item you know — well in those days it wasn't that big, now it is — it was like, if you're talking numbers, an album, a total album, musicians and singers, the first albums I did in 1956 I would say maybe $15,000, $12 or $15,000.

MR: No kidding.

RC: Now, musicians and singers, and I'm really, I go in with a time schedule and a budget. You know, I know what I'm doing. I don't go in there and spend four days on the bass drum you know, like some of the younger artists do, which is all right, they're selling more records that I am, I'm not knocking it you know. But I would go in and I could do four tunes a session, and I had it all worked out. But now, even working on a tight budget, I'd say a good hundred thousand dollars at least, for musicians and singers. And maybe you can get the cover in there too, the artwork on the CD. But that was in those days, ten or twelve, fifteen, thirteen thousand. But anyway, they paid all of that, and I got the three percent above that. But anyway they got me up then what was called the top royalty, five percent. And they had two different kinds of contracts. Some of the contracts were on wholesale. We're getting too complicated. Some were wholesale, some were retail. But I had the best I could get at the time. Yeah. To answer you really, the quick answer to the question is, when you're selling product, you get a good deal. When you're not selling, it's tough to get the top deal.

MR: Three percent of nothing isn't very good.

RC: Yeah, right.

MR: I've noticed that at that time you had a timeframe that you had to work in, or that you chose to work in, for each song, that as I look at these titles, the longest cut I see is like three minutes and fifteen seconds. Was that mostly for a radio consideration or was it just for the listeners' attention span?

RC: Well there were two things that went into that. The radio was a very big part of it, airplay. If you had a song that was 3:15 and someone else had a song that was 2:15, and the guy's making up his show, he would pick the 2:15 unless he really wanted to play, you know, because he wanted to get more commercials in. And we were all kind of keeping our cuts down as much as we could, because we got a better chance of airplay on the cuts if they were around 2:15 — 2:20 was ideal. To go under it you were getting, the buyer wasn't getting enough music, and you didn't really have a chance to get a good idea in the arrangements. The other thing was that on the album sides, long cuts — well let's see — we were putting out twelve songs to an album originally, six on a side. And they

eventually cut that to five on a side because of the royalties and the payments for the songs you know. Let's see you asked about the timing.

MR: So if you write your arrangement then, you had to actually figure out what's the tempo of this song, and kind of time like how many choruses can I do, should I go to the bridge here sooner than I was going to. You had to keep in mind the time as you put the structure of the song together.

RC: Yeah. Like you'll have a watch — this is a second hand and like if I was here and I got a great idea and I said, "do you mind if we stop the tape a minute" I can sing myself eight bars and stop it, and say okay let's go on, and I can go home and I can remember the song and what the tempo was by the eight bars. Yeah I would time everything out, and would shoot for around — well I didn't make it a real rule, you know, because you always had some songs in there that you put in there for airplay. I remember on the album of "Broadway and Rhythms," "On the Street Where you Live" was almost 2:10, something about like 2:10, and I got a lot of airplay on that. So that was the cut in that album. I knew the guys would play that cut out of the album, because everybody liked that. So I didn't worry too much, maybe another one could be up around three. Another thing, I wonder if the people that might hear this might be interested in knowing, we don't have an album in here, but in the middle of this album, when you're playing an album, when the needle's out here, the revolutions of the record player in those days is always the same, 33-1/3 revolutions per minute. So when the needle is out here, it's going around this big long circumference. When it's in here, it's going a very short distance in the same period of time. The quality is much poorer here. The quality is three times as good out here as it is here. And we had to think about that, in the timing of the album, how far apart the grooves were, and how far we would go in here. Because you'd get to a certain point here, and the quality got so poor in there that you didn't want to use it anymore.

MR: I never thought of that.

RC: We don't have that problem with CDs and numbers and digital and all of that.

MR: Yeah. And it relates to tape speed too. When if you tape something—

RC: No tape speed is determined what's going across the heads. It's pulled through the heads by the rollers. Well actually the reel is going faster or slower, but the speed of the tape through the heads is always the same.

MR: Oh. Okay.

RC: 15 IPS we used to record, and now we double it.

MR: Did that idea of the songs that are in the middle of the record, might not sound quite as good, did that determine what arrangements you might put in there?

RC: Not so much as the first band would determine. You figure when a disc jockey got a new

people were going to listen to the first band and maybe skip to the second. We always thought those were the most important bands. That if they liked the first couple of bands they'd buy the album or they'd put it on the air. So those were the ones. We didn't pay too much attention to the inner bands because we knew the quality wasn't as good anyway.

MR: Wow. I never thought of that.

RC: I don't know if other artists — maybe other artists never thought of those things. But I was very commercial and looked at all aspects of the business. I got into the covers and everything.

MR: Yeah, talking about the process of recording music, I mean you've seen from your days with Bunny Berigan up until your most recent one hundredth album, which I wanted to mention, you've seen a great deal of change in the actual technology of recording. Do you think it's affected the music in the way it's written, the way that technology has changed the recording of it?

RC: It has in this way, that well let's see, it's hard to answer that. You know I think overdubbing has changed things a little bit. Because I remember as long as I've been in this business you're always learning new things. The very last album I did was this one here called "I Love Movies" which is a very new album. It just reached the market, and it's movie themes, stuff like "Star Wars," John Williams — I have two John Williams in, he's great, I love John Williams, "Star Wars" and "Can You Read My Mind," — talk about, you know, melody and bass line, now you're talking about a musician you know. And all of kind of today's movie themes. I was recording and I was going to overdub the singers on "Can You Read My Mind," which had lyrics. Usually if I have lyrics — by the way, I do everything simultaneously. I'm going back, I went through — in the beginning I recorded everything simultaneously in the studio, and then I tried a period of time where I went to the overdubbing technique by going in, record the rhythm section you know, and then I'd bring the brass and then saxes or the brass in and record to the rhythm, or bring the saxes in and record to the brass and the rhythm, and then bring the singers in and add them on top of everything. And this — we're going to get into a technical thing now, but we're getting into something that really improves the quality of each section in that you don't have the sound of the drums, like in the first recordings we did, I'm going back now into '56, the one you first heard. You don't have the drums. When the drum catches a punctuation by the brass, he leaks into some of the other mics, which changes the drum sound, which changes things around. But leakage is not that bad. But when you do the rhythm tracks alone and you put the drummer in a booth by himself, all you hear on the drum tracks is the drum, no leakage. So in other words, you don't get drums

Nice." You don't get brass leaking into singers, like we have on "S' Wonderful." You don't get brass leaking into piano, and drums leaking into piano. And you get clean tracks on everybody. But you do lose something I think. You lose the idea of 28 people in the studio at the same time recording a piece of music and hearing what everybody else is doing, and how the finished product is sounding. With the brass overdubbing technique, you do your rhythm tracks and the drummers are hearing the guitars on earphones. The guitars aren't next to him. He's not feeling them the same. And when the brass come in to overdub to the rhythm, they're wearing earphones. He's not really hearing the trumpets next to him as much as he did — well he has one ear and he does hear out of here, he hears the other trumpet, but it's a whole different ball game. And one has advantages and disadvantages, and the other has advantages and disadvantages. I prefer everybody live in the studio at the same time. If you need a little more singers on something that had words, overdub them. And you have a feeling of excitement and fun that is on the record that doesn't get there by the overdubbing technique. Now let's see, what got us into this — you asked about changes—

MR: In the recording process.

RC: Well that's why I thought we should mention overdubbing, because I think that changes it a bit. It changes the writing a bit when you think you're writing for overdubbing and not for something else, you know not for live. I think basically the answer would be no, wouldn't it? That you wouldn't change a lot because of the techniques.

MR: I had noticed, I'm not sure I have this cued up to —

[audio interlude]

MR: Can you place that arrangement?

RC: Oh that's Billy Butterfield, "Just Kiddin' Around," isn't that the name?

[audio interlude]

MR: I noticed in this particular recording, as opposed to some of the other albums, that there was just a lot more reverb.

RC: I went overboard. I'll be honest with you. We did two albums, Billy Butterfield and I. One was called [coughs extensively]

We did two albums with Billy Butterfield. One was called "Conniff Meets Butterfield," and the other was called "Just Kiddin' Around." The first one was very successful and a real fun album, and I tried to do the same thing. You never quite can do the same thing again. And I felt after I heard that back I felt I went overboard with the reverb a little bit. It's exciting, but I don't know, I think if I did it over I'd either do a little different reverb or not quite so much, I don't know which. But now I can't remember what got us into that.

MR: Oh I was just talking about I guess the sound of your recordings and the technology. And sometimes I wonder when a new device comes out, whether it's a digital reverb, or whether it's synthesizers you know, digital synthesizers, if it becomes a tool to use, and sometimes that because it's popular at that time maybe you over-use it and then later on you think that that's not the way to go anymore.

RC: Yeah, it happens. Like the syn drums, remember the syn drums? I used those for a while and then I stopped using them because they were being used so much. I think that on the whole things have gone forward recording-wise. I'm using synthesizers now. I used them on this last album, CD. I don't use them quite the same as the younger artists use them. I've tried using them with my sound, you know that voice instrument sound that I became known for, and in that I would use like men singers with sometimes double unisons right with trombones and low saxes. Girls with double unisons with trumpets and higher saxophones. And I tried, hey I think I'll embellish that, let's try going a little further, let's use a synthesizer with it as well. So we did a whole album once like that. I had about three or four synthesizers. I had one synthesizer was working with like the girl, brass, like a guy would play even single line things you know. I had three great keyboard guys on there, I remember I had Dick Hyman and I had oh God, I can't think of the guys, but anyway three great jazz piano players and they're all playing synthesizers. But anyway we found that we would double one synthesizer with the girls and trumpets, and one with the men and the trombones, and then another one was sustaining a pad like a string section would be. And we found that they couldn't phrase. Like let's take one of my old things like "Smoke Gets In Your Eyes." It starts with trombones and men and they go, and low saxes, and they go [scats]. You know you can't get that forte piano on the synthesizer. They go [scats]. So what you would hear, you'd hear the men and the trombones going [scats] and then you'd hear [scats] and they would keep going. And I'd say to the guy, can't you use the pedal? They couldn't do it.

MR: Not that quick, yeah.

RC: It's too hard. It could be done if they did that for a living, you know. So we discarded that completely because it wound up in the mixdown, I had to bring the synthesizer down so much that you wouldn't hear that on the trombones and men or the girls and trumpets. But what we did find was the sustain pad of the string sound was really good. So we used that all the way, we used that quite a bit on "I Love Movies," the new CD. And I do use that. And you know I've heard things that are done for movies and TV shows, the guys are doing it out in their garages, and they are great you know — big, big, big sounds and good sounds. So I think things on the whole have gone forward sound-wise. And I guess in that respect, yes it does change writing. The guys that are writing for synthesizers and

out. You know they might have it all up here, and might be sketching stuff and doing it all themselves in the garage you know.

MR: Yeah. Because you can almost, of course they have devices now that you can play a part on a keyboard and it will be printed out in manuscript. So, amazing things out there nowadays.

RC: Yeah.

MR: I notice you have a fan club in Germany?

RC: Yeah, well, I think there's only one. That's the Ray Conniff International Fan Club, yeah.

MR: And your records have been all around the world. I wanted to ask you as we wrap up here, let's suppose, I think one song that you didn't pick on here, let's say you were going to do an arrangement on, are you familiar with the song from "The Lion King," "Can You Feel The Love Tonight?" Let's suppose you wanted to give that your treatment. How do you, when you sit down, do you sit down at a keyboard, or do you just think about it in your head, what am I going to do with this particular song? How exactly is it going to start?

RC: By the way, I don't know if you know my background, but you might notice, this is with a different label, this is my first CD with Polygram. And I'm quite excited about it, because it brings out an answer to your question. When we did the music for this, the fellow that asked me to come with Polygram after being with Columbia Records which became CBS Records which became SONY Music, I outlasted — 40 years I was with the company — I outlasted three name changes and two buyouts. But anyway this fellow that is head of Polygram, the international department, was with SONY Music and he came to a concert, came backstage, "Ray, why don't you come on Polygram." He says, "how are things going with SONY?" I says, "oh they take me for granted after 40 years, they don't promote." He says, "come with me, I'll promote you." So he's been doing, he sent this kit out. So anyway, when we first met about what I should do, which answers your question, I said, "well what do you think we should do for a first album?" And he came up with the "I Love Movies" idea, you know with the heart for the love. And he said, "I'm going to send you a cassette of not ten — we were going to put ten songs originally, it wound up twelve. He said, "I'll send you not ten, but I want to send you about 30 songs of movie themes, because he says, I want you to go through them." And he says, "what I've noticed about when Ray Conniff does an arrangement of a song, it kind of becomes your song in a way, because it's different than it was any other time anyone else did it." He says, "I want you to listen to 30, and pick ten that you can make your sound on." And that's the way I did it. So I took the 30 and went through all 30, and I listened to each one quite a bit. And I will first work with the sheet music and first I'll listen to the theme as it

My Mind." And then I will get the sheet music out and sit at the piano and just kind of see what comes to me. And I'll make notes up on the piano part of ideas that came to me on that. And I went through all 30, and I make kind of pencil notes on the piano bar. Or I might grab a piece of manuscript or something if there wasn't room to put it on the piano part, and I'll put "Star Wars" on the outside and scribble out a little line that I have. Like on "Star Wars" what comes to me is that I started fiddling with the chords of "Star Wars," and I happened to be in G, which "Somewhere My Love" was in. And I'd just come from a rehearsal with the singers and we'd been rehearsing that, and I started playing [scats], which is the same as the piano background of "Somewhere My Love." I says hey you know what? That would work on this. And I just took the G, D, G, B, G, D, G, D, B, C [scats]. And used the "Somewhere My Love" background piano pattern with "Star Wars." And [scats] I did a much slower tempo. And used the trombones and men and low saxes for the theme [scats]. And so I'd write that idea down, and go through all 30. Then I'll go back through and I will think about, I'm leaving it up to him to send me 30 that he says to him it doesn't make any difference which ten I pick. And I will think though about you know, "Star Wars" had a lot of publicity. You know it had a big push. So if I can fit in with songs that have had — like if now I was doing it I'd certainly have put some stuff from "Titanic" in you know, it's so big, that people are going to see songs from "Titanic" in the CD and they're going to lean towards that. So I'll lean that way a little. But on the whole, I'll get the best ten ideas and those are the ones that will wind up in the album.

MR: Great. Well I wish you a lot of success with it and I am fascinated by your combination over the years of business sense, with the great musicianship. That's rare. I think that's rare. Because I've talked to a number of people who bemoan the fact that the people in power in the music world these days seem to have no musical sense or whatever. And so it's nice to see it.

RC: Well there has been quite a change. When I started I mentioned Mitch Miller who was an oboe player, and Goddard Lieberson who was president of Columbia Records was a graduate of Juilliard. And they were musicians, or if they weren't musicians they were guys that wished they could have been musicians that were in [coughs]
they were musicians or guys that at least wished they could have been musicians. Now in the record companies they are more concentrating on what's at the bottom line, how much money did we make or lose, and they have accountants and attorneys running the companies. And I liked it better when the musicians were running the companies. I owe a lot to the fellows that gave me my chance you know, to do that, and I owe a lot to disc jockeys too, they played the heck out of my stuff in the beginning, and fellows like you

Beat and *Record World* and *Variety* and those magazines, *Billboard*. They really gave me a lot of space. Of course in the final analysis I had owe a lot to the people that I hit that heart string and recorded that song they fell in love to, and they went out and bought the albums. I have to thank all them too. They've been great and they've stayed with me for years.

MR: Well I think probably there's a lot of song composers that are very fond of you also, because I'm sure some of them have gotten some royalties out of all the records you've sold, because of the great arrangements you've written of their music.

RC: It's been fun because I've been able to do what I've done all the years through the band days and the big band days and playing trombone — I still play trombone, when I go out on the tours I'll play a little Jack Teagarden, I'll play "Basin Street Blues," or "I've Got a Right to Sing the Blues" or something. And I still have great musicians in the band. And it's fun to play what I call good music, but still done in a way that the people that are out there listening and coming to the concerts can understand and enjoy as well.

MR: Well that sounds like a great way to wrap up. And I want to say on camera that I'm very grateful to you for making the trip down from L.A. also, with the things going on in your life and you're busy, and I really appreciate your coming down. And I wish you all the best.

RC: Gee I never listened to a sound check. I know on the kit they sent out the sound wasn't very great, but I hope everything came out all right, but I've had a little rasp in my throat.

MR: Well I also noticed on one of, on the tape that they sent that you like to sing along but it's "off mic" you said.

RC: Oh, yeah, yeah, I have no chops. I don't have a good sound. Yeah I do sing along with the horns and voices, but I prefer it if they don't get me too predominant on a mic.

MR: Okay, well it was a great pleasure talking to you.

RC: Thank you very much, Monk, and gee lots of success. I understand you've got about a hundred others, interviews like this in there. I hope some day I may get back to see you and may be able to see a little of them.

MR: Please when you come out to view the fall colors in the east, maybe we can have you as a guest.

RC: Okay, well I must take your card and your address along. Are you anywhere near 80 or 70? Route 70 or 80? The big east-west highways? Are you near 40? You'd be up north.

MR: We are on the New York State Thruway, I-90.

RC: 90. Yeah. You'd be up, I'd have to go through the northern route to go through your area probably. Okay.

MR: Thanks so much.